

Brown surprises India with his brand of realism and support of a greater role for Delhi in the global arena

AFP PHOTO/NICHOLAS BRADLEY



profile grows, it will do well to have more friends like Britain.

Brown knew that with many key countries already waiting to open the nuclear door to India, he shouldn't stay behind. He announced British support for the Indo-US civil nuclear agreement and an appropriate India-specific exemption in NSG guidelines. Both countries agreed to promote cooperation in the civil nuclear sector and work towards a bilateral agreement. For India, this was a major step as no agreement has been negotiated so far with Britain, who were wary of cooperating in the nuclear arena with India.

Counter terrorism fared high on the agenda and Brown proposed closer coordination between the Indian and British security agencies. The two leaders also agreed to share intelligence and learn from each other's best prac-

of the Organisation of Economic Cooperation and Development that deals with curbing terror-funding and money-laundering. India's entry in FATF will be important given the recent intelligence assessments about terrorist funds flowing into India's stock market.

With bilateral trade touching close to £9 billion (Rs 70,00 crore) and 500 Indian companies operating in the UK, economic relations have boomed, with big British brands like Vodafone and Virgin doing well in India, and Tata Motors in talks to acquire Landrover. The relationship has been on an upward spiral and the two leaders agreed to clear curbs to promote trade.

While the two sides were on the same page on most issues, there were some differences. When Brown pushed for India meeting the targets of the post-Kyoto agreement on climate change to ensure all carbon emissions are reduced in the world and make greater investments in renewable and alternative sources of energy, New Delhi gently reminded him about the developed world sharing its responsibility. India also politely declined Britain's request of including the carbon capture storage technology in the joint statement. But, after its initial reluctance, Britain did accept India's argument of factoring in per capita emissions in the climate change negotiations.

For Brown, who aspires to don the mantle of a statesman, the visit to India was an opportunity to present himself as an advocate of the UN millennium development goals of eradicating poverty. He announced a development package of Rs 6,381 crore for India to be spent on health and education over the next three years. The British delegation was keen to include all this in the joint statement and the Indians obliged. While both sides agreed to undertake various development projects in other countries, New Delhi was cold to Britain's suggestion of implementing them in Africa.

While the big challenge for the two sides will be to ensure that all declarations get to the implementation stage fast, the positive outcome is that there is a greater degree of confidence here that, under Brown's leadership, the Indo-British partnership will be a high priority for 10, Downing street and will be kept on the fast track. ■

BROWNIE POINTS

- Brown vows support for India's seat at the UN Security Council and supports its candidature for the G-8. India and Britain to work on a civilian nuclear agreement.
- New bilateral dialogue on terrorist financing to be started. India to join the Financial Action Task Force.
- The duo announce a partnership to work on development projects in third countries.
- UK wants India to do more to put pressure on the military regime in Myanmar and take steps to restore democracy.

tices in securing the transport systems and mounting a terror-proof security set up for the 2010 Commonwealth Games and the 2012 Olympics in London. "I would like to see greater contact between our two countries in winning the battle of hearts and minds, isolating extremist ideologues that try to poison young people and the views that they have," remarked Brown.

The two countries also agreed to work closer on curbing terror funding, and on enhancing civil aviation security. New Delhi also secured Britain's support for membership to the Financial Action Task Force (FATF)